WHY NITISH SWITCHED AGAIN

GIVING UP ON I.N.D.I.A., THE JD(U) CHIEF DOES A VOLTE FACE TO GET BACK WITH THE BJP. IS THIS ANOTHER WINNING MOVE OR HAS THE MASTER OF U-TURNS LOST HIS WAY?

By **AMITABH SRIVASTAVA**



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On January 15, Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar took one of his rare strolls down the road from his official residence to Lalu Prasad's residence at 10, Circular Road, for a Makar Sankranti feast the latter had organised. On the outside, it seemed a festive gathering of two alliance partners. There was Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) chief Lalu holding hands with Nitish, son and deputy CM Tejashwi overseeing the platter for the CM, praise for the *kodhe ki sabzji* (pumpkin stew), Nitish tapping Lalu's shoulder to whisper an aside, and everyone posing for pictures.

But all of it could not hide the veil of unease over it all. The Janata Dal-United (JD-U) chief left soon and did not speak to the media. And though Tejashwi saw him off, the bonhomie of the past 17 months had clearly fizzled out. Rumours of a rift between the two alliance partners continued to spiral.

It took just four days for trouble to surface, so much so that Lalu and Tejashwi paid a visit to Nitish's residence on January 19. Tejashwi later told the media that all was well and the grand alliance will contest the Lok Sabha polls unitedly. The next day, the cabinet coordination department issued a notification, announcing portfolio changes for three RJD ministers, including education minister Dr Chandrashekhar, whose sparring with his additional chief secretary had irritated Nitish. As it turned out, it was only a diversionary tactic.